ESSENTIAL LECTURE 01

Introduction to Desktop Publishing

and Visual Communication

Clear publications begin with a clear message—not with the software.

ITT06105 • Ordinary Diploma in Information Technology • 2026/2027

What should you be able to do?

By the end of this lecture, focus on these four practical outcomes.

01 Explain DTP

Describe desktop publishing in your own words and name everyday products made with it.

02 Read a visual message

Identify the audience, the main message and the intended action.

03 Apply basic principles

Explain hierarchy, contrast, alignment, proximity and repetition.

04 Improve a weak notice

Identify specific problems and suggest a clearer layout using paper sketches.

Desktop publishing is already around us

Look at the information people see every day—not only at books and magazines.

Event poster

Announces an activity

College notice

Gives instructions

Brochure

Explains a service

Lesson hand-out

Supports learning

Newsletter

Shares updates

Digital graphic

Communicates on screen

What is desktop publishing?

Desktop publishing (DTP) is the process of using computer software to arrange text, images and other visual elements into a finished publication for print or digital sharing.

Example: a department notice needs accurate words, visible event details, organised spacing and a shareable final file.

DTP is more than typing

Word processors can also make attractive pages, but publishing puts deliberate page communication at the centre.

Typing and editing

The main task is to enter words, correct mistakes and form readable paragraphs. A letter or ordinary report may need little visual arrangement.

Desktop publishing

The task includes choosing information, arranging it into a reading order, combining suitable graphics and checking how the finished page will print or display.

Both may use the same computer. The difference is the communication and layout decisions being made.

How desktop publishing became accessible

The tools changed, but the need to communicate clearly remained.

1

Before personal DTP

Many pages were prepared using specialist typesetting and manual production methods.

2

1980s onward

Personal computers, page-layout programs and printers brought publishing to smaller organisations.

3

Print and screen

Digital photography, PDF files and online sharing expanded where publications are used.

Why does DTP matter to organisations?

Inform people

Colleges and community groups prepare notices, schedules and learning materials that readers can scan quickly.

Build consistency

Repeated headings, logos and layouts help different publications look like they belong to one organisation.

Prepare usable output

A publication must remain legible when printed or opened on another device. Saving the right file is part of the work.

What is visual communication?

Visual communication means conveying a message through the appearance and arrangement of text, pictures, symbols, shapes, colours and space.

A reader should be able to recognise what matters first, find the supporting details and understand what to do next.

Correct information can still be poorly communicated

A weak notice might...

Use tiny pale writing for the venue, arrange details in random positions and place a decorative picture over essential information.

A stronger notice...

Makes the event name immediately visible, groups its date and venue, uses readable contrast and removes elements that distract from the message.

Good design supports accurate content; decoration cannot replace accuracy.

Start with three questions

Before opening any design application, decide what the publication needs to accomplish.

1

WHO is the audience?

Students, residents, parents, customers or another specific group?

2

WHAT must they know?

The event, service, topic or instruction that must be understood.

3

WHAT should they do?

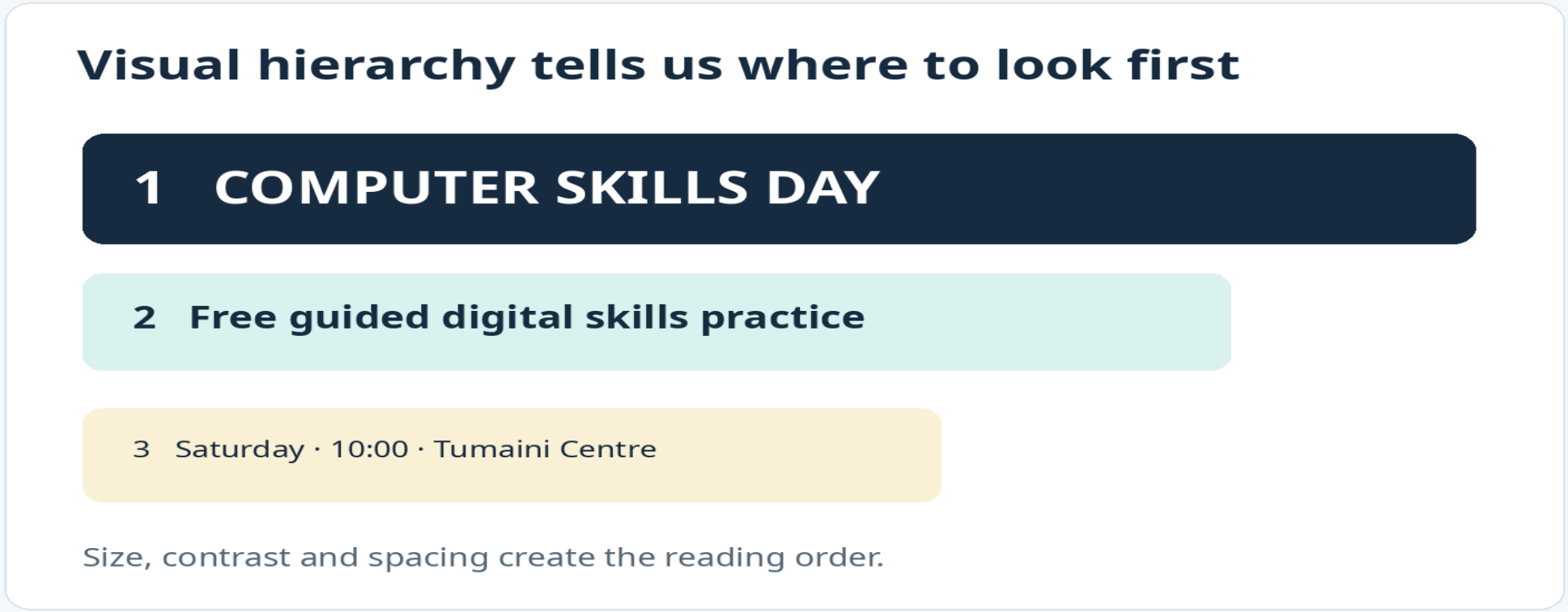
Attend, read further, make contact, apply or follow a procedure.

Five qualities of a clear publication

1	**Clarity**	The central message is easy to understand.
2	**Accuracy**	Names, dates, contact details and instructions are correct.
3	**Readability**	Words are legible, with suitable size and contrast.
4	**Suitability**	Language and visual style match the intended audience.
5	**Consistency**	Similar elements look related throughout the page.

Visual hierarchy: guide the reader’s eyes

Size, contrast and spacing establish a deliberate reading order.



Hierarchy is more than “make it bigger”

What the reader notices first

A large event name or lesson title identifies the subject immediately. The headline should be meaningful, not just decorative.

What comes next

A short explanation gives context. Date, place, instructions and contact details are then grouped so they can be located quickly.

A good reading order depends on the reader’s needs—not every detail should be equally prominent.

Study this crowded event notice

The information exists, but many elements compete for attention.



Look for:

- competing type sizes and colours
- inconsistent left edges
- event details scattered apart
- decoration that distracts

A clearer version of the same message

Grouping and contrast direct the reader from the headline to the event details.



What improved?

The event title forms a clear headline. Supporting text is easy to scan. The date and time appear together. Alignment and open space make the page calmer.

Compare the two designs—not just their appearance

The stronger notice gives the reader a more predictable path through the information.

BEFORE · DIFFICULT TO SCAN



AFTER · CLEAR READING ORDER



Four principles that organise a page

These terms give us practical reasons for improving a design.

Contrast

Differentiate important information from supporting details.

Alignment

Use consistent edges and lines to establish order.

Proximity

Put related information together, and separate unrelated groups.

Repetition

Reuse visual features so headings and sections feel consistent.

Contrast helps important information stand out

FAINT HEADING

CLEAR HEADING

Contrast can come from colour, size, weight or shape. Use it to express priority, not to make every object compete.

Alignment creates a reliable structure

WITHOUT ALIGNMENT

Event title

When it happens

Where to go

WITH ALIGNMENT

Event title

When it happens

Where to go

Consistent left edges help the eye scan. They also make a publication look more deliberate.

Proximity reveals which details belong together

A confusing arrangement

The time appears near the fee, while the venue is isolated beneath unrelated contact text. Readers must work out what belongs to the event.

A clearer arrangement

Place date, time and venue inside one event-details block. Give registration and contact details their own neighbouring block.

Spacing communicates relationships even before the reader understands every word.

Repetition makes a document feel consistent

Section heading

Use the same typeface, size and colour each time a new section begins.

Information box

Repeat a similar border, fill or spacing style when the same kind of information appears.

Page identity

A repeated header or logo can show that several pages belong to the same publication.

Repetition brings unity. Contrast still helps distinguish the most important item.

Whitespace is useful space—not wasted space

CROWDED LAYOUT



CLEAR LAYOUT



The empty areas separate groups and make the important parts easier to notice.

Gestalt: how we perceive groups and patterns

Gestalt principles describe common ways in which people see visual elements as belonging together or standing apart.

Proximity

Nearby elements are often read as one group.

Similarity

Items with matching shapes or colours appear related.

Figure and ground

A clear contrast separates the main subject from its background.

Three Gestalt ideas in a picture

Notice how distance, repeated shapes and contrast affect what seems connected.

PROXIMITY

Nearby items look related.



Group A Group B

SIMILARITY

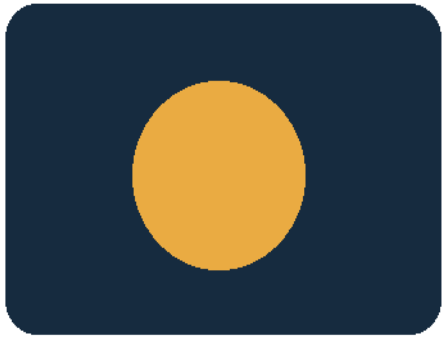
Matching items appear grouped.



Colour and shape create groups

FIGURE / GROUND

The main item stands out.



High contrast isolates focus

Design is a reasoned decision, not personal taste

“The date is hard to find.”	Move it into the event-details group and give it readable contrast.
“The page feels disorganised.”	Use consistent alignment and spacing for headings and paragraphs.
“Everything is shouting.”	Reduce competing emphasis and establish one clear headline.

Choose software that matches the publishing task

Photoshop

Suited to editing photographs and raster image compositions. A common task is cropping or correcting a photo for a notice.

Illustrator

Suited to vector artwork that can be resized, such as icons and logos.

InDesign

Suited to arranging text and graphics into pages, brochures and booklets.

Also consider available computers, licences, skills, file compatibility and output requirements.

Which tool would you choose?

1

Edit a photograph

A raster editor helps crop or retouch the image before it is placed in a publication.

2

Create a small icon

A vector editor keeps simple shapes clear at different display sizes.

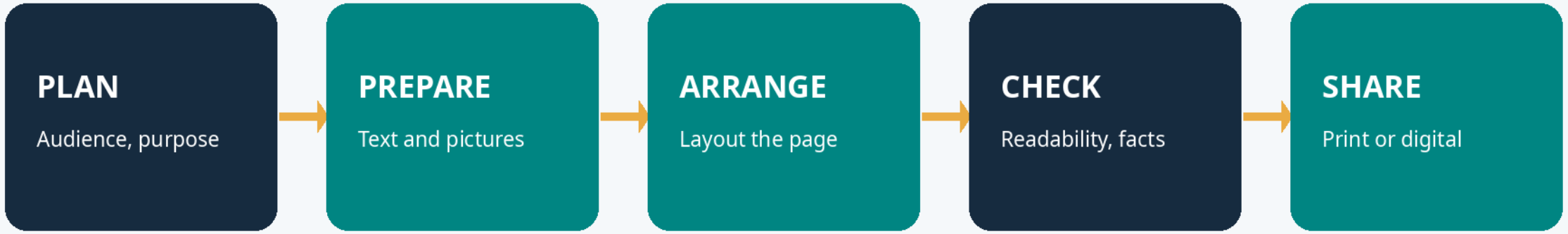
3

Build a booklet

A page-layout tool helps maintain columns, image placement and styles.

A simple desktop publishing workflow

Prepare the message, build the page and check the result before anyone else reads it.



The process is not always perfectly linear. A failed check may send the designer back to correct content or layout.

Check these five things before sharing

1	**Audience**	Would the intended readers understand the words?
2	**Accuracy**	Are the names, times, dates and contacts correct?
3	**Hierarchy**	Can readers spot the main message in seconds?
4	**Readability**	Is the text large enough and sufficiently contrasted?
5	**Output**	Does the file display or print as expected?

Practical: diagnose the original notice

Use the printed activity sheet. No specialist software is required.



Explain, do not just label.

Identify the intended audience, message and action. Then describe three difficulties and link each one to a design principle.

Useful words: hierarchy • alignment • proximity • contrast

Sketch a clearer version and explain your choices

1

Plan

Write down the headline and essential date, time and venue.

2

Rearrange

Sketch blocks with a clear reading order and enough whitespace.

3

Justify

Describe at least two changes and how they help readers.

Three quick self-check questions

1 Why is desktop publishing more than ordinary typing?

Explain in terms of page arrangement and communication.

2 How do alignment and proximity help a reader?

Use one simple event-notice example.

3 What should a reader see first on an event poster?

Explain why that order serves the intended audience.

What to remember

Desktop publishing prepares a message for print or digital reading. Good visual communication starts with the audience and purpose, then uses hierarchy, contrast, alignment, proximity, repetition and spacing to make information easier to understand.

NEXT: Core Lecture 2 — Text, Images and Colour

For independent study: full L01 notes and selected Gestalt examples from full L05.